

WEEK 1 LESSON GUIDE

WONDER

BIG IDEA

We worship because God is holy.

BIBLE

Psalm 8:3–4, 24:1–3, 89:5–6; 1
Peter 1:13–16; Colossians 3:9–10

ABOUT THIS WEEK

Standing at the base of a towering mountain or gazing out from its summit can leave us speechless, but nothing compares to the wonder of God's holiness. This week, we'll look at God's unmatched power and be reminded to reflect that holiness in our lives. When we recognize just how distinct God's character is, it's no wonder that **we worship because God is holy.**

WHAT? What are we talking about?



See the Hacks



ACTIVITY | Summit Everest

- Welcome to the first week of *Wonder*! This month, we'll be exploring the natural wonders of the world! One of the most well-known wonders is Mount Everest. Many people travel to see it each year, and thousands attempt to climb it.
- You can't just show up to Mount Everest ready to climb, though. It's so high you need special equipment and a ton of training to reach the top. And even then, it's still dangerous.
- *Everyone* who climbs it needs help. One of the best groups to help is a group of guides called *Sherpas*. They're local, experienced climbers who help carry extra supplies, guide groups in difficult weather, and use their expertise of the mountain to lead others.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *For this activity, you will need blindfolds, [graham crackers](#), [marshmallows](#), and [chocolate](#). Borrow sleeping bags, pop-up tents, and cameras. Divide your group into pairs, each with a blindfolded "climber" and a guide. Create a camp-themed obstacle course where the guides lead their partners through a series of challenges. Time the groups—the fastest pair wins! Here are some ideas for the base camp challenges:*
 - Camp 1: Set up a pop-up tent
 - Camp 2: Make a s'more
 - Camp 3: Unroll a sleeping bag and then pack it up again
 - Summit: Take a selfie at the summit.
- Whether you're climbing Mount Everest or packing up a sleeping bag with a blindfold on, we all need help from time to time. The same can be true for our faith.
- See, people climb Mount Everest to experience something special. They want to go where no one else will go. To do that, they need someone to lead them to a place where they can have the experience they're looking for.
- When it comes to our faith, we want to feel like we're in a relationship with God and

not just going through the motions. Our faith is something we want to **experience**. But it's not always easy to get there, is it? Sometimes, we need help finding our way or navigating a "storm" in our life. If we keep going, we can experience something amazing.

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups.*
 - **If you had the chance to climb Mount Everest, would you go for it? Why or why not?**
 - **What's one place of natural beauty in the world you want to visit?**

POLL | This Experience Or That One

- Before we go any further, let's take a quick poll. Amazing experiences can change based on people's perspectives. One person might love climbing the highest mountain in the world, while another might love something a little less... dangerous. So, which experiences would you prefer?
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *Poll your teenagers' responses to the following questions. You could ask them to respond by raising their hands, standing, or shouting out their answers.*
 - **Looking at a mountain or climbing one?**
 - **Scuba diving with sharks with or without a cage?**
 - **Jumping from the top of a waterfall or swimming peacefully in the pool of a waterfall?**
- Something about each of these experiences fills us with a sense of wonder. It's like we recognize there's so much beyond ourselves, right?
- They either leave you speechless or make you go, "Wow," nonstop. Well, scuba diving with sharks might cause a different reaction, but you get the idea! Those reactions happen because we're responding to something big, incredible, and powerful. That sense of awe and wonder is at the heart of worship.



See the Hacks



QUESTION | What is worship to you?

- "Worship" is one of those words that churches use all the time. It's easy for us to nod our heads, thinking we know what it means, but let's take a minute and share.
What is worship to you?
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *Give a few students the chance to respond.*
- There are so many different thoughts about worship and how you do it. Some people love to worship by singing songs to God. Others prefer writing poetry and journaling. As you've all just heard, we can interpret worship in different ways.
- In fact, that can lead us to wonder...
 - Is there a "best" way to worship?
 - Can I worship when I don't feel like it?
 - Why is worship so hard to do sometimes?
- If we're honest, we don't always **feel** like worshipping God. And even when we want to, we face so many distractions. Between that and the constant buzz of life, it can

be tough to create space in our lives and set aside time to focus on God.

- So, for the next few weeks, whether worship feels awkward for you or you already have your own habits of worship, we're going to explore this sense of wonder that God inspires within us. As we do, we'll see that worship isn't about singing the "right" songs or feeling the "right" emotions. It's about what happens when we give in to wonder.

SO WHAT? Why does it matter to God and to us?



See the High
School Hacks



SCRIPTURE | Psalm 24:1–3

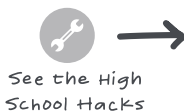
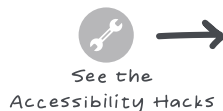
- The book of Psalms is a collection of poems and songs that all speak to who God is. If we want to understand worship and why we do it, one of the best places to start is with Psalms. Some psalms use creation and nature as a lens to talk about how different God is than all other parts of the universe.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Read Psalm 24:1–3.
- Simply put, God is different from us because God *created* us. God created everything we see and interact with on a daily basis. It was God who set everything in motion long before we ever existed.
- This psalm imagined God high up on a mountain—maybe like Mount Everest—overlooking all of creation. But there's a difference. Unlike any other mountain, God isn't someone you can easily reach. God is holy, apart from all of creation. No one is more important or even on the same level as God.

SCRIPTURE | Psalm 89:5–6

- In fact, it wasn't just *people* who couldn't measure up to God. It was *all creation*.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Read Psalm 89:5–6.
- The psalm writers understood that God is different from people, the skies, and the "assembly of the holy ones," or anyone surrounding God. Even the angels can't compare to God's holiness. That's how different God is. There's no one like God.

SCRIPTURE | Psalm 8:3–4

- We can see this truth whenever we look at nature and places like Mount Everest. We can see God's fingerprints in the world.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Read Psalm 8:3–4.
- When we look at the world around us, we can see just how different God is. I mean, think of all the incredible experiences you go through each day. God created all of this for our benefit.
- The writer of this psalm could see it. They knew the stories of God creating everything, but they also took the time to see it in the world around them. God's hand is in all of it. As they noticed God's work, they chose to do something different—they worshiped. They responded to God's holiness with poems and songs.
- That's what worship is. It's responding to moments—whether amazing, difficult, or normal—that you have with God. These psalm writers responded to their experiences of God with awe and wonder. They wrote poetry and songs to sing alone and with others.



- Through their experiences, they understood that God was holy—high above the rest of creation. And their experience of God's holiness inspired them to worship.

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.*
 - ***How would you describe the feeling of wonder?**
 - ***Other than being the Creator, what other characteristics make God distinct?**

VIDEO | A Clip of a Flyover of Mount Everest

- We started this lesson talking about Mount Everest, so it's only right for us to look at incredible footage of what the summit looks like. This is drone footage that really captures just how massive Mount Everest is. Let's take a look.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *As a teaching tool, play a short clip from a video like [this one](#) (1:35–2:40), of drone footage of Mount Everest. We always suggest viewing the clip beforehand to ensure you think it's a video that will be a good fit for your context! [Read this](#) for more information on legally using copyrighted material for educational purposes!*
 - Did you see the people there? They were so tiny compared to the mountain. It was like looking at ants from far away! Mount Everest is so high that I bet getting even halfway up the mountain feels like you've conquered the world.
 - Mount Everest is the highest mountain in the world, but isn't it wild that we can fly a drone to go **even higher**? People can actually look down on that huge monolith!
- But can we do that with God? No. God is so big and so beyond our imaginations that we could never create something bigger. As tall and massive as Mount Everest is, God—the one who created this wonder—is **even bigger**.
- God is different from anything in this world and so huge that we're filled with awe and wonder when we try to understand God. That's holiness again, showing up on mountaintops and drone footage to remind us that what we see is amazing—and God is even more so. When we look at the world around us and see and experience how big and different God is, we can respond with worship.

SCRIPTURE | 1 Peter 1:13–16

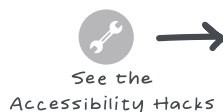
- What does it look like to worship? Do we just sing some songs about God being different and call it a day? Do we write poems and our own songs like in the book of Psalms? Or is there something else we can do, a different way for us to worship God?
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *Read 1 Peter 1:13–16.*
- When we experience how amazing and different God is, we can respond with worship—but that isn't just about reflecting on God's nature through praise and singing. We can also (and are invited to!) worship by reaching for holiness in everything we do and every aspect of our lives.

- It's really easy to read this passage and get a little bummed. We might think about our lives and wonder if we're good enough or holy enough for God. But that's not the point. We aren't God and won't ever be, but we can worship by trying to be more like God.
- Worship is really two parts. You can share it, like in songs and poetry, and you can live it. Just like God is different, you can live in a way that's different. Thankfully, you don't have to figure this out alone because God has given us a blueprint to follow through Jesus and the Bible.
- The ending of this verse tells us God is holy or distinct from anything else. We're invited to try and live in a way that reflects that holiness in ways that are distinctly like God. So, we can worship God by trying to live differently from the world around us. Remember, **we worship because God is holy.**

NOW WHAT? What does God want us to do about it?

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups.*
- **What do you see in nature that makes you feel like creation calls out in praise to God?**
- **Read Colossians 3:9–10. Since we are being renewed in the image of our Creator, what are some characteristics of God that are being developed in you?**



REFLECTION | Climbing The Mountain

- **We worship because God is holy.** God has invited us to have amazing experiences and then respond in worship—not just through song but in our lives, too! Like a Sherpa guiding us to the top of the mountain, God invites us to keep moving forward on our journey to grow in our faith.
- But that path doesn't come easily. To climb the mountain, you'll need to train and develop the skills needed for your journey. Here are a few ways you can get started.
 - **DECIDE:** Choose to live differently! It's so easy to copy others but much harder to live differently. Through incredible wonders like Mount Everest, God is calling you to take a step of faith and guiding you to live differently. That's the first step in climbing a mountain—you have to decide that you want to reach the top.
 - **STOP:** We all have habits and decisions we've made that might keep us from getting closer to our goals. If we want to grow in our faith, we'll have to really consider what needs to stop. It might be a relationship, an attitude, a behavior, or something else that's keeping you from growing. God's call to holiness is an invitation to turn away from those habits so we can move closer to God. What is God inviting you to **stop** doing?
 - **START:** Stopping a habit is only helpful if you replace it with something better. What do you need to help you live out holiness in the world? Do you need to make a habit of reading your Bible or going to church more regularly? You might trust your leaders more and ask those questions that have been sitting in the back of your mind. Your team of leaders would love

to help you unpack the new habits you can start so you can thrive on your journey.

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Before the program, print out the [handout](#) in the Week 1 folder. Place them under chairs prior to the program, or have leaders pass them out upon your request. Starting with the peak of the mountain, have your group write down the decision they want to make about living differently. Then, have them write what they would like to stop and the habits they'll need to start to reach their goal.
- Right now, we're going to help you start thinking about how to respond to God's call. On this handout, write down a big goal you have for your relationship with God that will help you reflect or respond to God's holiness. Maybe you want to share your faith with someone, or maybe you want to make a habit of journaling about God's holiness every day. Whatever it is, write your big goal in the box—the big, unique experience you hope to have with God.
- Then, you'll need to think and talk with God about how you'll get there. What changes do you need to make? And what do you need to start doing so you can grow closer to God and develop your faith?

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.
 - ***Why do you think it is important to worship God authentically?**
 - **What is holding you back from worshipping God, and how can we help you worship God fully?**
 - **What is one way you can practice worshipping because God is holy this week?**

MUSIC | "The Earth Sings Worthy" (UPPERROOM)

- The Psalms we read today show us that God's holiness isn't a secret. From day one, all of creation has witnessed God's holiness—even the heavens praise God's wonders! Now, we're invited to experience this for ourselves.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Play the song "The Earth Sings Worthy" (UPPERROOM), but make sure you have purchased any required licenses. [Read this](#) for more information on legally using copyrighted material for educational purposes! [Here's a link](#) to preview the song for your personal use. As you play the song, invite your students to spend some time worshipping by saying thanks for all the amazing ways they have experienced God.
- We can look at the world around us, these wondrous monuments of God's majesty and holiness, and know they aren't just nice to look at. They can be experienced as reflections of God's nature and character. They're like signposts showing all the amazing ways God wants to encounter and transform our lives.
- These natural beauties fill us with awe and wonder, can help draw us closer to God, and remind us of God's holiness. Then, we can join all of creation as we worship in response. **We worship because God is holy.**

